



ANGELS fans wave their shirts and chant “sell the team” at Angel Stadium on May 20, frustrated by years of losing under Arte Moreno. On Tuesday, the owner agreed to sell the Angels to Rams owner Stan Kroenke.

A push to pump brakes on Big Tech

California lawmakers advance flurry of bills aimed at social media, AI and data centers.

By QUEENIE WONG AND DAKOTA SMITH

SACRAMENTO — Long the epicenter of the global tech industry, California is taking more action to shield its children, communities and workers from the threats posed by the very industry that’s become central to the state’s identity and enviable economy.

State lawmakers on Monday passed new safeguards around social media, artificial intelligence and data centers at a time when technology has become intertwined with people’s daily lives.

Efforts to rein in the power of Big Tech extend beyond concerns that TikTok, Instagram and other social media platforms are harming young children.

Unions and workers worry that AI will take their jobs, and lawmakers are trying to tackle privacy and safety issues as AI features get added into smart glasses and toys. Californians are concerned that the proliferation of data centers will increase their electricity bills and strain water supplies.

“There’s a heightened level of tech anxiety right now, and that manifests itself from social media to data centers to AI taking jobs,” said Assemblyman Josh Lowenthal (D-Long Beach). “People are coalescing and they’re demanding that policymakers make change.”

California Gov. Gavin Newsom, who has previously vetoed some bills aimed at adding restrictions on Silicon Valley businesses, will [See **Big Tech**, A11]

Rams owner to buy Angels for \$4 billion

By SAM FARMER AND BILL SHAIKIN

Rams owner Stan Kroenke has agreed to buy the Angels, adding Major League Baseball to a portfolio that spans six leagues and two continents.

The deal marks the end of Arte Moreno’s turbulent ownership of the Angels, with the news triggering shock followed by celebration among beleaguered fans whose team owns baseball’s longest active playoff drought.

The transaction runs through Kroenke Sports & Entertainment, Kroenke’s holding company, which also owns the Denver Nuggets of the NBA, the Colorado Avalanche of the NHL, the Colorado Rapids of MLS and Arsenal of the English Premier League.

The Angels are being sold for an MLB-

record \$4-billion valuation, a person with knowledge of the deal not authorized to discuss it publicly told The Times. The previous high was the \$3.9-billion sale of the San Diego Padres that was completed last month.

Forbes had valued the Angels at \$2.8 billion in March. The sale is subject to regulatory review and MLB approval, with the expectation it will close in the first quarter of next year.

Companies tied to Kroenke also own the Rams and built SoFi Stadium and the 300-acre Hollywood Park development around it in Inglewood, a project that has grown into a sports and entertainment hub for Los Angeles County and is set to host events during [See **Angels**, A8]

PLASCHKE: Light up the halo, the Angels have a guardian. SPORTS, B10



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

CLOSURES posted in Laguna Beach on Tuesday warn of hazardous conditions.

A rain check for Labor Day

Developing hurricane in Pacific could cause flooding

By RONG-GONG LIN II

Could Southern California be at risk of flooding from the remnants of a hurricane this Labor Day weekend?

It’s a possibility, some weather experts say, and scientists are closely watching Tropical Storm Marie develop Tuesday in the eastern Pacific Ocean, south of the Baja California peninsula. Marie is expected to turn into a hurricane by Wednesday, the National Hurricane Center said.

There’s high uncertainty over the path the storm will take, the National Weather Service office in San Diego said. But its development underscores the weather conditions that have affected Southern California this summer: unusually hot ocean temperatures and intense humidity.

The threat of extreme weather is expected to intensify this winter, with a “very strong” El Niño climate pattern forecasted in the central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean. If El Niño per-

forms as expected, it’ll trigger changes in the atmosphere that will move the winter storm track farther south, sending above-average rain and big waves to Southern California and risking a season of erosion and flooding on the coast.

The intense storm activity in the Pacific this summer may be a preview of what’s to come.

The development of Marie comes amid an unusually active hurricane season in the eastern Pacific. [See **Storm**, A7]

Whistleblower says USPS defied court on ballots

‘Faulty’ system could cut off delivery of materials for millions, several lawmakers say.

By KEVIN RECTOR

The U.S. Postal Service is rushing to implement President Trump’s new rules for mail ballots — despite a court order barring it from doing so — using “an entirely new and untested set of IT systems” that could cause “catastrophic problems” in the November election, according to an agency whistleblower.

“Potentially millions of American voters may not receive their mail-in ballot this election cycle in a timely manner, or at all,” the unidentified whistleblower alleged in a statement published Tuesday by Sen. Richard Blumenthal (D-Conn.), the ranking Democrat on the Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations.

Among other issues, the whistleblower alleged that the Postal Service’s new Federal Ballot Mail Portal for verifying mail ballots — which Trump demanded in a March executive order and

California and other states are challenging in court — has been built in a “slapdash” manner and is “fundamentally flawed.” Thousands of ballots would be invalidated whenever a single ballot’s newly designed Postal Service barcode isn’t properly read, the whistleblower said.

“As presently designed, if even one bar code on one single ballot in a bulk-mailing of 10,000 ballots fails to properly scan during the verification process, the entire batch is rejected and sent back to the state — effectively stopping the ballots from being mailed to voters,” read the whistleblower’s statement, which the group Whistleblower Aid helped draft.

A Postal Service spokesperson said in a statement to The Times that the agency was “carefully reviewing the concerns” raised by Blumenthal and the whistleblower, welcomes oversight and is committed to transparency.

The agency has spent months developing its portal “to provide election officials with a simple, secure, and efficient way to share lists of individuals receiving [See **Ballots**, A6]

L.A. taxman goes after jet-set celebs

Plane owners may not know about property levies. That doesn’t fly with assessor.

By REBECCA ELLIS

Jeff Bezos got hit with a notice for about \$244,000 in overdue L.A. County taxes and fees on his luxury jet.

A private aircraft that, according to flight tracking database JetSpy, is linked to Rihanna racked up a roughly \$104,000 bill for unpaid taxes.

Stan Kroenke, the billionaire owner of the Rams, got dinged about \$290,000 for two private planes that JetSpy says belong to him.

L.A. County Assessor Jeff Prang is on a mission: Find the ultrawealthy jet owners who failed to pay taxes on their luxury planes and make them cough up.

Private jet owners in California have to pay an annual 1% property tax on their plane. Airplanes are taxed in the place that they are “habitually situated” when not in flight. That means it doesn’t matter where a

plane is registered or where the owner lives, but rather where the plane has spent the most time on the ground. If they fail to pay, they get charged a penalty fee.

This year, the assessor’s office sent out hundreds of bills to plane owners that the office said failed to pay the tax on time. The revenues are expected to pad the county coffers with an extra \$38 million, while infuriating many of the region’s richest residents who insist they had no idea they needed to pay.

“One thing that is very clear is that private aircraft owners in Los Angeles County, and, likely, across California, have been very successful in evading assessment and taxes,” said Prang, who won reelection in June. “We knew that we were missing things. Obviously, the details here show that we missed a lot.”

The Times obtained the list of jets owing taxes through a public records request and then linked them to a star-studded assortment of celebrities, business tycoons and tech titans using [See **Planes**, A7]



KEVIN DIETSCH Getty Images

ARMY SECRETARY IS OUT

Dan Driscoll, left, is the latest military leader to depart under President Trump. Tensions with Pete Hegseth, center, were reported. **NATION**, A4

Mother’s battle is now children’s

Columnist Steve Lopez speaks with daughters, son of Eaton fire victim who was fighting to go home. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 84/64. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Jewish support for Mark Ruffalo

In letter, artists call out Paramount’s “smear campaign” against the actor. **BUSINESS**, A9

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Two ’90s rap slayings, one still unsolved

Tupac Shakur murder case ends in guilty verdict. But Biggie Smalls case stays cold.

By RICHARD WINTON

For decades, two of the music world’s most notorious killings remained unsolved.

First, Tupac Shakur was gunned down on the Las Vegas Strip in 1996. Six

months later, Christopher Wallace, known as Biggie Smalls, was fatally shot on Wilshire Boulevard after a music event at the Petersen Automotive Museum.

Both killings captivated the public and seemed tied to gang feuds involving the rap world. But despite lengthy investigations, amateur sleuthing and endless speculation, neither case came to a resolution.

Until this week.

On Monday, a Las Vegas jury found a onetime Comp-

ton gang leader guilty in the slaying of rapper Shakur.

It took jurors only a few hours of deliberation to find that Duane “Keffe D” Davis had orchestrated the fatal 1996 shooting of Shakur as the rapper sat in a BMW next to Death Row Records founder Marion “Suge” Knight. The 63-year-old Davis, convicted of murder, faces a potential life sentence.

Davis was always a prominent figure in the case, writing a book about the murder

that included self-incriminating passages. Prosecutors used his words as the central part of their case.

Legal experts say the conviction marks a victory for law enforcement officials, whose investigations into both slayings were mired in uncooperative witnesses, questionable police work and what in retrospect seem like missed opportunities.

Police had known about a potential connection between Davis and the Shakur [See **Slayings**, A6]